



JOHN M. SETZLER Jr. | HICKORY DAILY RECORD

Angela Beaver Simmons and Dr. Dave Scott prepare to release a rehabilitated bald eagle at Bud Geitner Park on Saturday.

Raptor release

Eagle, hawk take flight after recovery

By Richard Gould

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HICKORY

A crowd of hundreds gathered under gray skies to watch a 5-year-old bald eagle spread its wings and fly across Lake Hickory before landing in the top branches of a tall pine, on the other side.

The eagle had been brought to the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville, where it was treated for what was believed to be a concussion, said staff veterinarian Dave Scott of the Raptor Center.

Ten days after it arrived, it was strong enough to be released.

The crowd parted to make room for the bird to be carried to the lakeside. It was wrapped in a

towel and canvas to control and protect it.

The wraps were removed and the eagle struggled to free itself before being tossed into the air toward the lake. Once it had gotten some distance from the crowd, it appeared to be in no great hurry and took its time as it found a perch across the lake.

Scott said the center does outreach programs every year where birds are released into the wild after being rehabilitated. Lake Hickory was an ideal location for a bald eagle, he said.

"This is a perfect spot — there's a population of eagles here," he said.

The center had planned to release a juvenile bald eagle, but that bird had reinjured itself and required additional time to recu-

perate.

The eagle wasn't the only raptor released Saturday. The center also released a Red-tailed Hawk.

The hawk had been shot. Its wing had been shattered. Surgery to implant three pins and 136 days to recover from the operation were required before the bird was healthy enough to release at Hickory's Bud Geitner Park.

The event was a joint effort presented by the Catawba Science Center and the Carolina Raptor Center.

Catawba Science Center Executive Director Alan Barnhardt had served as CEO and president of Carolina Raptor Center

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Beau Simmons of Hickory and Anne Steinert of the Carolina Raptor Center release a rehabilitated Red-tailed Hawk on Saturday afternoon at Bud Geitner Park in Hickory.

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for more than eight years before taking the helm in Hickory.

Barnhardt said one of his main priorities is collaborating and cooperating with organizations to bring events like this one to the people of Hickory.

A Barred Owl and a Red-

tailed Hawk will be on loan to the Science Center from the Raptor Center. The injuries that brought the animals to the Raptor Center were so severe that the animals can no longer survive in the wild.

The birds of prey can be seen up close at the Science Center's TreeHouses exhibit through May 16.

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